

Borers and burrowers

Life can be dangerous out in the open, and food can be hard to find. Many animals solve these problems by tunneling through their food, or burrowing underground. Using their mouths, feet, or even shells, they eat or scrape their way through their surroundings, staying safely out of sight. Some burrowers, such as naked mole rats, spend their entire lives below ground. Others use their burrows as a base, emerging after dark to feed or to breed.



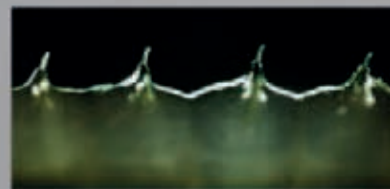
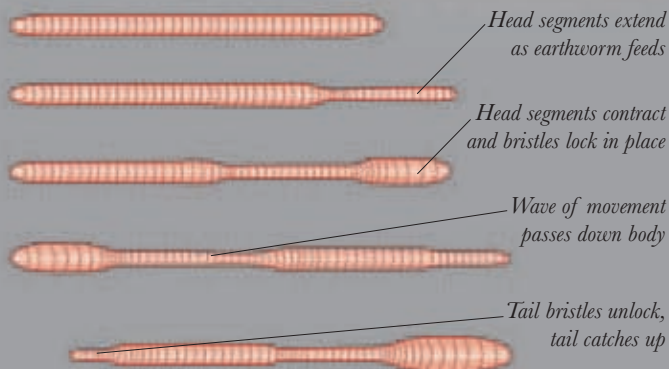
Living drills

Shipworms are clams with sluglike bodies and small, sharp shells. They use their shells like drills to tunnel through submerged wood. In the past, they were a major problem for wooden sailing ships.



How worms burrow

Earthworms may feel smooth and slippery, but they are stronger than they seem. To burrow, an earthworm contracts and relaxes its muscular segments in a set sequence to produce waves of movement down the body. Earthworms usually tunnel near the surface, but in dry weather, they can dig more than 6½ ft (2 m) deep to coil up tight until wetter times return.



Getting a grip

An earthworm's segments each have four pairs of tiny bristles, or chaetae. When a body segment is contracted, it bulges out, and its bristles lock against the soil. This anchors the segment, so that the worm can push through the ground.